

Giving presentations

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Giving presentations

- Tell them what you are going to tell them.
- Tell them.
- Then tell them what you told them.

—Ian Parberry

What is the purpose of your talk?

- Not to go through the paper!
- Rather, to make people read the paper later.
- A talk is an *advertisement*, not a substitute for the paper.

Ask yourself

- Who will be listening? Specialists, or the whole conference?
- What is the one thing you want them to remember?
- What will they do next — look up the paper, the code, you?

Don't ...

- Don't impress the audience with hairy theory.
At most 1–2 technical slides. Use motivating examples instead.
- Don't present more material than you have to.
Better to spend the detail on *one* thing.
- Don't hide the problems with your method.
They will find out ... and it is better coming from you.
- Don't start with an outline.
A five-minute talk does not need a table of contents. Use “signposts” along the way instead.
- Don't read from your slides.
Talk about what is on them. Keep notes for each slide.
- Don't fiddle with the slides while you talk.

Timing

- Give practice talks — out loud, standing up, with a clock.
- Never *ever* run over.
- Budget roughly 1–2 minutes per slide, and check against a real rehearsal; the number varies enormously with how dense your slides are.
- Know which slides you will drop if you are running late, and mark them.
- Put a “check the time” marker a third and two thirds of the way through the deck.
- If the session chair gives you a five-minute warning, go straight to your conclusions slide.

Outline for a talk

1. Title slide with the title, the authors, and where you are from.
2. Get yourself ready: slides up, microphone on, clock visible.
3. Have the opening sentence memorised.
4. Then:
 - define the problem;
 - an example that demonstrates it;
 - prior work on the subject;
 - summarise your contribution;
 - present your results;
 - 1–2 technical slides on the method;
 - conclusions;
 - open problems;
 - “Thank you. Any questions?”

Making the slides

- *Tools:* beamer for a $\text{\LaTeX}$ talk with real mathematics; PowerPoint, Keynote or Google Slides otherwise. Nobody will judge you for the tool; they will judge you for dense slides.
- Use 16:9. It has been the projector default for years, and a 4:3 deck wastes a third of the screen.
- At least 20 pt body text. If it fits in 14 pt, it does not belong on a slide.
- One idea per slide. A slide is a visual aid, not your notes.
- Prefer a figure to a bullet list, and a bullet list to a paragraph. Never paste a table straight out of the paper.
- Number your slides — people refer to them in the questions.
- Dark text on a light background survives a bright room better than anything clever.

Slides people can actually read

- Check the contrast. A projector in daylight loses every subtle shade you chose on your laptop.
- Do not encode meaning in colour alone — roughly 1 in 12 men has some form of colour-blindness. Use shape, position or a label as well.
- Say out loud what is in the figure. This helps the people at the back, the people on the video stream, and anyone who cannot see it.
- Axis labels and units on every plot. Readable ones.
- If you must show code or a proof, show the three lines that matter, not the screenshot of the whole file.

Before you go on

- Bring the talk as a *PDF*. Fonts and animations travel badly; PDF does not.
- Three copies: laptop, USB stick, and somewhere online. Assume one of them fails.
- Test the adapter. Test it on *that* projector, in the break before your session.
- Avoid live demos and anything needing the conference wi-fi. If you must, record the demo beforehand and play the video.
- Know how to get presenter view up, and how to get out of it when it goes to the wrong screen.
- Turn off notifications before you share your screen.

Online and hybrid talks

- Camera at eye level; look at the *camera*, not at the faces.
- Light on your face, not behind you.
- A cheap headset microphone beats the laptop's built-in one every time. Sound matters more than picture.
- You lose the room's feedback, so slow down and pause deliberately.
- Share a single window, not the whole desktop.
- Someone should watch the chat for you — you cannot present and read chat at the same time.
- Assume it is being recorded and will outlive the session.

The question and answer session

Three kinds of question:

1. **The self-admirer**

“Have you read Dr. Smith’s paper?” — where Dr. Smith is the questioner.

Thank them, say you will look it up, move on.

2. **The attacker**

“Your work is boring / irrelevant / contrived.” “This is just a variation on X.”

Stay polite, give a one-sentence answer, and offer to continue afterwards. The room is on your side, and it stays there as long as you are calm.

3. **Genuine interest**

This is the one you came for. Answer it properly.

And say “I don’t know” when you don’t — it costs you nothing and buys you a great deal.

Handling questions

- Repeat the question before answering it. Half the room did not hear it, and it buys you a few seconds to think.
- Answer the question that was asked, not the one you prepared for.
- Short answers. If it needs five minutes, take it offline.
- If you genuinely do not understand the question, ask them to rephrase it. That is not a defeat.
- Silence at the end is normal, not a verdict. Have one question of your own ready for the chair to throw back at you.

In short

- The talk sells the paper; it does not replace it.
- One idea per slide, and few slides.
- Rehearse with a clock, and never run over.
- Bring a PDF and a spare copy of it.
- Be honest about the weaknesses — it is the cheapest credibility you will ever buy.

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